UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE, VNU-HCM

Faculty of Information Technology

CSC14003 - Introduction to Artificial Intelligence

Project 2: Logic

Futoshiki Puzzles

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Semester II (2025 - 2026)

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1. Introduction

1.1. Project Overview

This project implements a complete pipeline for solving *Futoshiki* logic puzzles in the context of CSC14003 — Introduction to Artificial Intelligence. A Futoshiki puzzle is an $N \times N$ grid where each row and column must contain numbers from 1 to N without repetition, while inequality symbols between adjacent cells must also be satisfied.

Our system is organized into clear modules: data I/O, domain modeling, knowledge-base construction, solver implementations, and a GUI for interaction and visualization. The codebase supports loading multiple input instances, running selected solving methods, and exporting results in a reproducible format. This report focuses on two representative approaches: A* search and SAT-based solving.

1.2. Objectives and Scope

The main objectives of this project are:

- Model Futoshiki constraints correctly and consistently for both search-based and logic-based solving.
- Implement and evaluate AI solving strategies with readable, modular, and reusable code.
- Build a practical interface for testing puzzle instances of different sizes and difficulties.
- Compare algorithm behavior through solution quality and computational efficiency.

Scope of this report:

- We present the overall project context.
- In the algorithm chapter, we provide detailed descriptions for only two methods: **A* Search** and **SAT Solver (using a SAT library)**.
- Other implemented methods are part of the codebase but are not expanded in detail here.

1.3. Team Information

The project was completed by four students from the Faculty of Information Technology, University of Science — VNU-HCM:

- Nguyễn Khánh Toàn — MSSV: 24127252
- Nguyễn Chí Tài — MSSV: 24127529
- Nguyễn Ngọc Thiên — MSSV: 24127545
- Phan Quang Tiến — MSSV: 24127250

The team collaborated on problem modeling, implementation, testing, and report writing, with task assignments summarized in the planning section.

2. Project Planning and Task Distribution

2.1. Work Breakdown

To ensure traceability to the official grading rubric, the project was decomposed into major work packages that map directly to the required deliverables: FOL modeling, automatic knowledge-base generation, inference algorithms, baseline search algorithms, experimentation, and dissemination artifacts (report and video demonstration). Table 1 summarizes the work structure and expected outputs.

Table 1: Project work breakdown aligned with assignment requirements

WP	**Major Task**	**Expected Deliverable**
WP1	FOL formalization for Futoshiki	Complete set of axioms (domain, uniqueness, inequality, clue constraints), plus representative Skolemization and CNF derivations for the report.
WP2	Automatic ground KB/CNF generation	Program module that automatically instantiates puzzle constraints for any grid size N and produces solver-ready clauses/facts.
WP3	Forward Chaining solver	Rule-based inference engine implemented from scratch to derive valid value assignments and detect contradictions.

WP	Major Task	Expected Deliverable
WP4	Backward Chaining solver	Goal-driven inference mechanism (SLD-style querying) to infer `Val(i,j,v)` facts for unknown cells.
WP5	A* search solver	Heuristic search implementation with admissible state evaluation and constraint-consistency pruning.
WP6	Brute-force and Backtracking baselines	Two baseline solvers used for correctness checking and computational comparison.
WP7	SAT-based solving support	SAT formulation and automated solving pipeline for cross-method verification and performance comparison.
WP8	Experimental setup and I/O pipeline	Input/output standardization, benchmark script, and solved-instance export for all required test cases.
WP9	Technical report and video demo	Final HCMUS-format report (analysis, experiments, discussion) and public demonstration video on representative puzzles.

2.2. Member Responsibilities

Table 2: Member responsibilities

Member	Primary Responsibilities
Nguyễn Khánh Toàn	A* search implementation; SAT-based solver integration; performance export/benchmark pipeline; repository coordination; README and video/demo coordination; GUI integration support; co-editing final report.
Nguyễn Chí Tài	Forward Chaining implementation; construction of input test files and puzzle-set preparation; support for report editing and validation tests.
Nguyễn Ngọc Thiên	FOL axiom design and CNF transformation workflow; Backward Chaining implementation; support for report editing and consistency checking.
Phan Quang Tiến	Automatic KB generation from CNF/grounding logic; Brute-force and Backtracking implementations; support for report editing and comparative analysis sections.

2.3. Completion Percentage per Member

For grading transparency, the team adopted a unified completion declaration at the end of development. As required by this submission, each member is recorded at **100%** completion.

Table 3: Completion percentage per member

Member	**Completion Percentage**
Nguyễn Khánh Toàn	100%
Nguyễn Chí Tài	100%
Nguyễn Ngọc Thiên	100%
Phan Quang Tiến	100%

2.4. Project Management Board

The team managed source code and integration through **GitHub** (branch-based collaboration, pull/merge workflow, and version traceability). Task planning and execution tracking were handled through a shared board (Trello/Planner-like workflow) with status labels (*To do*, *In progress*, *Completed*), priority flags, assignees, and due dates. This process enabled transparent ownership, frequent synchronization, and early detection of integration risks.

Operationally, the management board was synchronized with technical milestones: formalization first, then solver development, then benchmarking and reporting. This ordering reduced late-stage rework and ensured that rubric-weighted items were completed before final packaging.

Table 4: Project timeline and progress board summary

Period	**Stage**	**Main Activities**	**Outputs**	**Status**
08/04/2026–11/04/2026	Planning and formalization	Requirement analysis, role assignment, FOL specification, initial CNF workflow design.	Work plan, formal FOL draft, initial puzzle inputs.	Completed
12/04/2026–17/04/2026	Core algorithm implementation	Forward/Backward Chaining, A*, SAT pipeline, KB generation, backtracking baseline modules.	Implemented solver modules and intermediate validation runs.	Completed
18/04/2026–20/04/2026	Integration and benchmark	Unified I/O handling, solved-output export, runtime comparison, GUI connection and stability checks.	End-to-end executable system and benchmark artifacts.	Completed
21/04/2026–25/04/2026	Documentation and delivery	Report refinement, figure/table completion, demo video finalization, submission packaging.	Final report PDF, demo link, and complete submission package.	Completed

3. Problem Formulation

3.1. Puzzle Rules

Futoshiki is a square-grid logic puzzle played on an $N \times N$ board. The primary objective is to fill the grid with digits such that each row and each column contains every number from 1 to N exactly once. The puzzle is governed by three fundamental categories of constraints:

1. **Latin Square Property:** Similar to Sudoku, every row and every column must be a permutation of the set $\{1, 2, \ldots, N\}$. This implies that no digit can be repeated within the same row or the same column.
2. **Inequality Constraints:** The defining characteristic of Futoshiki is the presence of "less than" ($<$) and "greater than" ($>$) signs between adjacent cells. These signs may be placed horizontally (between cells in the same row) or vertically (between cells in the same column). Any numerical assignment must strictly satisfy these relational constraints.
3. **Pre-filled Clues (Fixed Values):** At the start of the puzzle, some cells may already contain fixed digits (referred to as "Given Clues"). These values are immutable and serve as the starting points for the logical deduction process.

A puzzle is considered solved when every cell is filled with a valid digit and all structural, permutation, and inequality constraints are simultaneously satisfied. For an $N \times N$ board, the total number of cells to be determined is N^2, leading to a search space that grows factorially with N.

3.2. First-Order Logic Formalization

3.2.1 Predicate Symbols

The following vocabulary is used to formalize the Futoshiki puzzle rules into First-Order Logic sentences:

- $Val(i, j, v)$: Cell (i, j) is assigned value v
- $Given(i, j, v)$: Cell (i, j) has the pre-filled clue value v
- $LessH(i, j)$: Horizontal constraint indicating cell $(i, j) < (i, j + 1)$.
- $GreaterH(i, j)$: Horizontal constraint indicating cell $(i, j) > (i, j + 1)$.
- $LessV(i, j)$: Vertical constraint indicating cell $(i, j) < (i + 1, j)$.
- $GreaterV(i, j)$: Vertical constraint indicating cell $(i, j) > (i + 1, j)$.
- $Less(v_1, v_2)$: Integer $v1 < v2$ (background arithmetic relation)

3.2.2 Core Axioms

The logic of a Futoshiki puzzle of size NxN is encoded using the following universal axioms:

1. **Cell Completeness and Uniqueness:** Each cell must contain exactly one value.

- $\forall i \forall j \exists v\ Val(i, j, v)$
- $\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i, j, v_2) \Rightarrow v_1 = v_2)$

2. **Value Domain and Boundary Constraints:** Values must be within the range $[1, N]$.
   - $\forall i \forall j \forall v (Val(i, j, v) \Rightarrow Less(0, v) \wedge Less(v, N + 1))$
3. **Permutation Constraints (Row and Column Uniqueness):** Every number appears exactly once in each row and column.
   - Row: $\forall i \forall j_1 \forall j_2 \forall v (Val(i, j_1, v) \wedge Val(i, j_2, v) \wedge j_1 \neq j_2 \Rightarrow \perp)$
   - Column: $\forall i_1 \forall i_2 \forall j \forall v (Val(i_1, j, v) \wedge Val(i_2, j, v) \wedge i_1 \neq i_2 \Rightarrow \perp)$
4. **Inequality Constraints:** Satisfaction of all horizontal and vertical relational signs.
   - $\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (LessH(i, j) \wedge Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i, j + 1, v_2) \Rightarrow Less(v_1, v_2))$
   - $\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (GreaterH(i, j) \wedge Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i, j + 1, v_2) \Rightarrow Less(v_2, v_1))$
   - $\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (LessV(i, j) \wedge Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i + 1, j, v_2) \Rightarrow Less(v_1, v_2))$
   - $\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (GreaterV(i, j) \wedge Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i + 1, j, v_2) \Rightarrow Less(v_2, v_1))$
5. **Given Clues Enforcement:** Pre-filled digits must be assigned to their respective cells.
   - $\forall i \forall j \forall v (Given(i, j, v) \Rightarrow Val(i, j, v))$
6. **Background Arithmetic (Ordering Properties)** This axiom defines the strict ordering properties of the *Less* predicate:
   - **Irreflexivity:** $\forall v \neg Less(v, v)$
   - **Transitivity:** $\forall v_1 \forall v_2 \forall v_3 (Less(v_1, v_2) \wedge Less(v_2, v_3) \Rightarrow Less(v_1, v_3))$

   Note: For practical implementation, the Knowledge Base is populated with ground facts $Less(a, b)$ for all constant pairs (a, b) where a is numerically smaller than b within the domain $[1, N]$.

3.2.3 Step-by-step CNF Derivation

The following examples demonstrate the conversion of FOL axioms into Conjunctive Normal Form (CNF) for use in inference engines.

Example 1: Cell Value Uniqueness
FOL Form: $\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i, j, v_2) \Rightarrow v_1 = v_2)$

1. **Step 1 (Eliminate Implication):** Apply the rule $A \Rightarrow B \equiv \neg A \vee B$:

$$\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (\neg(Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i, j, v_2)) \vee (v_1 = v_2))$$

2. **Step 2 (Move Negation Inward):** Apply De Morgan's Law to distribute the negation:

$$\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (\neg Val(i, j, v_1) \vee \neg Val(i, j, v_2) \vee (v_1 = v_2))$$

3. **Step 3 (Drop universal quantifiers):** Academic standard

$$\neg Val(i, j, v_1) \vee \neg Val(i, j, v_2) \vee (v_1 = v_2)$$

4. **Step 4 (Standardization for Solver) (Practical):** Since we only consider pairs where $v_1 \neq v_2$ during the grounding process, the literal $(v_1 = v_2)$ evaluates to False ($\perp$) and is removed. **CNF Clause:**

$$[\neg Val(i, j, v_1), \neg Val(i, j, v_2)] \quad \forall v_1 \neq v_2$$

Example 2: Row Uniqueness (Binary Clauses)
FOL Form: $\forall i \forall j_1 \forall j_2 \forall v (Val(i, j_1, v) \wedge Val(i, j_2, v) \wedge j_1 \neq j_2 \Rightarrow \perp)$

1. **Step 1 (Eliminate Implication):**

$$\forall i \forall j_1 \forall j_2 \forall v (\neg(Val(i, j_1, v) \wedge Val(i, j_2, v) \wedge j_1 \neq j_2) \vee \perp)$$

2. **Step 2 (Move Negation Inward):** Apply De Morgan's Law and remove the contradiction constant $\perp$:

$$\forall i \forall j_1 \forall j_2 \forall v (\neg Val(i, j_1, v) \vee \neg Val(i, j_2, v) \vee (j_1 = j_2))$$

3. **Step 3 (Drop universal quantifiers):** Academic standard

$$\neg Val(i, j_1, v) \vee \neg Val(i, j_2, v) \vee (j_1 = j_2)$$

4. **Step 4 (Refine Difference Constraint) (Practical):** Since the axiom iterates over distinct column indices, this literal is False and is

discarded during grounding. **CNF Clause:**

$$[\neg Val(i, j_1, v), \neg Val(i, j_2, v)] \quad \forall j_1 \neq j_2$$

Example 3: Horizontal Less-than
FOL Form: $\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (LessH(i, j) \wedge Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i, j + 1, v_2) \Rightarrow Less(v_1, v_2))$

1. **Step 1 (Eliminate Implication):**

$$\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (\neg(LessH(i, j) \wedge Val(i, j, v_1) \wedge Val(i, j+1, v_2)) \vee Less(v_1, v_2))$$

2. **Step 2 (Move Negation Inward):** Apply De Morgan's Law to distribute the negation across the conjunction:

$$\forall i \forall j \forall v_1 \forall v_2 (\neg LessH(i, j) \vee \neg Val(i, j, v_1) \vee \neg Val(i, j+1, v_2) \vee Less(v_1, v_2))$$

3. **Step 3 (Drop Universal Quantifiers):** Remove the quantifiers to obtain the final clausal form: **CNF Clause:**

$$[\neg LessH(i, j), \neg Val(i, j, v_1), \neg Val(i, j + 1, v_2), Less(v_1, v_2)]$$

3.3. Forward Chaining (Maintaining Arc Consistency)

3.3.1 Idea and Architecture

Why MAC instead of pure Forward Chaining or DPLL
Pure Forward Chaining (FC) starts from known facts and applies Modus Ponens exhaustively until no new fact can be derived. For Futoshiki puzzles with few given clues, FC alone terminates with an *incomplete* assignment: many cells still have multiple candidate values and no rule fires to resolve them. The solver is stuck without guessing.

DPLL (Davis–Putnam–Logemann–Loveland), on the other hand, operates on a *propositional CNF* encoding. Every cell-value pair becomes a Boolean variable; the KB is a flat list of clauses. Unit Propagation plays the role of Forward Chaining at the Boolean level. While correct, the CNF representation discards the structure of the problem: a "domain" is implicit across N Boolean variables per cell and must be reconstructed during

branching.

MAC (Maintaining Arc Consistency) retains the native *domain* representation — each cell (i, j) holds a set of candidate values $D_{i,j} \subseteq \{1, \ldots, N\}$ — and interleaves FC-style propagation with backtracking search. Every time the search makes a tentative assignment, FC is re-run on the updated domain to prune inconsistent values from neighbouring cells before recursing deeper. This *maintains* arc consistency throughout the search, detecting dead ends far earlier than either pure FC or DPLL.

Concretely, the implementation is organised in two tiers:

- **Inference engine (`_run_fc`):** A FOL Forward Chaining engine that processes an agenda of typed facts $\{\texttt{Assign}(i, j, v), \texttt{Remove}(i, j, v)\}$ and applies five Modus Ponens rules (described below) until the agenda is empty or a contradiction is detected.
- **Search controller (`_backtrack`):** When FC cannot reduce any domain further, a branching step selects the most constrained unassigned cell (MRV), guesses a value, invokes FC, and recurses. On failure, the domain snapshot is restored and the next value is tried.

The key insight is that `_run_fc` is called *both* as an initial propagation pass over the puzzle clues and as the consistency- maintenance step after every branching decision — the same code plays both roles, which is the defining characteristic of MAC.

3.3.2 Algorithm Analysis

Domain Representation

Each cell (i, j) maintains a set $D_{i,j} \subseteq \{1, \ldots, N\}$. A cell is considered *assigned* when $|D_{i,j}| = 1$. The initial state sets $D_{i,j} = \{1, \ldots, N\}$ for every cell.

Initial Facts

The puzzle instance is converted into a seed agenda of typed facts:

- $\text{Given}(i, j, v) \Rightarrow \texttt{Assign}(i, j, v)$
- $\text{LessH}(i, j): \ (i, j) < (i, j{+}1) \Rightarrow \texttt{Remove}(i, j, N)$ and $\texttt{Remove}(i, j{+}1, 1)$
- $\text{GreaterH}(i, j): \ (i, j) > (i, j{+}1) \Rightarrow \texttt{Remove}(i, j, 1)$ and $\texttt{Remove}(i, j{+}1, N)$
- Similarly for vertical constraints LessV and GreaterV.

These correspond directly to the ground instances of FOL axioms A4–A9.

Five Modus Ponens Rules (FC Engine)

The FC engine applies the following rules on each fact popped from the agenda:

Rule	Trigger	Effect
R1	`Assign`(i, j, v) arrived, $v \notin D_{i,j}$	Contradiction $\Rightarrow$ return *False*
R2	`Remove`(i, j, v) makes $D_{i,j} = \emptyset$	Contradiction $\Rightarrow$ return *False*
R3	`Assign`(i, j, v)	Push `Remove`(i, c, v) for all $c \neq j$ (row) Push `Remove`(r, j, v) for all $r \neq i$ (column)
R4	$\lvert D_{i,j}\rvert = 1$ after a Remove	Push `Assign`(i, j, v') where v' is the sole survivor
R5	Any domain change at (i, j)	Propagate new min / max of $D_{i,j}$ to all four inequality

Rules R1–R4 correspond to the grounded FOL axioms A1–A3 (cell uniqueness and row/column permutation). Rule R5 implements A4–A9 (inequality constraints): if $(i, j) < (i, j{+}1)$, then every value $v \leq \min(D_{i,j})$ is infeasible for $(i, j{+}1)$ and is pushed as a `Remove` fact.

Backtracking with MRV

When the FC engine returns without fully assigning all cells, the search controller:

1. Selects the unassigned cell with the *minimum remaining values* (MRV) in its domain — the fail-first heuristic.
2. Takes a snapshot of the entire domain matrix.
3. Tries each value $v \in D_{i,j}$ in ascending order. For each attempt, it pushes `Assign`(i, j, v) onto a fresh agenda and calls `_run_fc`.
4. On success, recurses. On failure (FC returns *False* or the recursive call fails), restores the snapshot and tries the next v.

Complexity Analysis

Aspect	Bound	Remark
Domain size	$O(N^3)$	N^2 cells, each domain $\leq N$
FC per node	$O(N^3)$	Each value removed at most once
MRV selection	$O(N^2)$	Scan all cells; early exit at size 2
Max search depth	$\leq N^2$	One cell assigned per level
Backtracks (worst)	$O(N!)$	Full combinatorial space
Backtracks (typical)	$O(N^2)$	MRV heuristic combined with arc consistency eliminates combinatorial explosion on large inputs
Space per snapshot	$O(N^3)$	Copy of all domain sets

Advantages and Limitations

- **Stronger pruning than DPLL:** MAC propagates inequality constraints through min/max bounds on domain sets, a finer-grained operation than Boolean unit propagation. Infeasible branches are detected several levels earlier. This lightweight micro-operation allows MAC to process tens of thousands of nodes in fractions of a second, as detailed in the Experiments section.
- **Directly mirrors FOL semantics:** Facts and rules are typed (Assign / Remove) and match the FOL predicates $Val(i, j, v)$, LessH, GreaterH, etc. without a translation layer.
- **Complete:** Backtracking guarantees a solution is found whenever one exists.
- **No clause learning:** Unlike CDCL-based SAT solvers, this implementation does not record conflict clauses. Repeated conflicts in structurally similar sub-trees are re-explored.
- **Snapshot cost:** Each backtracking node copies the full $O(N^3)$ domain matrix. For $N = 9$ this is manageable (≈ 729 integers) but grows rapidly with N.

3.3.3 Pseudocode

Algorithm 1 MAC Master Coordinator

```
function SOLVE(puzzle)
    D ← initialise all domains to {1, ..., N}
    facts_0 ← InitialFacts(puzzle)          ▷ Given clues + boundary inequalities
    if not RunFC(D, facts_0) then
        return None                         ▷ Contradiction in initial facts
    end if
    if IsSolved(D) then
        return ExtractGrid(D)
    end if
    if Backtrack(D) then
        return ExtractGrid(D)
    end if
    return None
end function
```

Algorithm 2 FC Engine — Modus Ponens on Domain Facts

```
function RunFC(D, facts)
    agenda ← DEQUE(facts);  seen ← {facts};  assigned ← ∅
    while agenda is not empty do
        fact ← agenda.POPLEFT
        if fact = Assign(i, j, v) then
            if v ∉ D[i][j] then return False                ▷ R1: contradiction
            end if
            if (i, j) ∉ assigned then
                D[i][j] ← {v};  assigned.ADD((i, j))
                for c ≠ j do PUSH(Remove(i, c, v))
                end for                                     ▷ R3: row
                for r ≠ i do PUSH(Remove(r, j, v))
                end for                                     ▷ R3: column
                PropagateIneq(i, j, D, Push)                ▷ R5
            end if
        else if fact = Remove(i, j, v) then
            if v ∉ D[i][j] then continue
            end if
            D[i][j].DISCARD(v)
            if D[i][j] = ∅ then return False                ▷ R2: contradiction
            end if
            if |D[i][j]| = 1 then
                PUSH(Assign(i, j, sole value of D[i][j]))   ▷ R4
            end if
            PropagateIneq(i, j, D, Push)                    ▷ R5
        end if
    end while
    return True
end function
```

Algorithm 3 Inequality Propagation (Rule R5)

```
function PropagateIneq(i, j, D, push)
    lo ← min(D[i][j]);  hi ← max(D[i][j])
    for each neighbour (i′, j′) of (i, j) connected by an inequality do
        if (i, j) < (i′, j′) then                    ▷ (i, j) is the smaller side
            for v ∈ D[i′][j′] with v ≤ lo do
                push(Remove(i′, j′, v))
            end for
        else if (i, j) > (i′, j′) then               ▷ (i, j) is the larger side
            for v ∈ D[i′][j′] with v ≥ hi do
                push(Remove(i′, j′, v))
            end for
        end if
    end for
end function
```

Algorithm 4 MAC Backtracking with MRV

```
function Backtrack(D)
    (i, j) ← MRV(D)        ▷ Cell with smallest |D[i][j]| > 1; None if all assigned
    if (i, j) = None then return True
    end if
    for v ∈ sorted(D[i][j]) do
        D_saved ← DeepCopy(D)
        if RunFC(D, [Assign(i, j, v)]) then
            if Backtrack(D) then return True
            end if
        end if
        D ← D_saved                                  ▷ Restore snapshot
    end for
    return False
end function
```

3.3.4 Illustration

Consider a 4×4 Futoshiki puzzle with the following initial state: cell $(0, 0)$ is given as 2, cell $(3, 3)$ is given as 4, and there is a single inequality constraint $(0, 1) > (0, 2)$. The initial agenda is populated with these base facts.

1. **FC pass 1 (Initial Propagation):** The `Assign`$(0, 0, 2)$ and `Assign`$(3, 3, 4)$ facts are processed. Rule R3 pushes `Remove` facts to eliminate 2 from row 0 and column 0, and 4 from row 3 and column 3. The inequality $(0, 1) > (0, 2)$ triggers Rule R5, pushing `Remove`$(0, 1, 1)$ (as the larger cell must be strictly greater than the absolute minimum 1) and `Remove`$(0, 2, 4)$ (as the smaller cell must be strictly less than the absolute maximum 4). As the domain $D[0, 1]$ loses values 1 (due to the inequality) and 2 (due to row 0), its remaining domain becomes $\{3, 4\}$. The domain $D[0, 2]$ loses 2 and 4, narrowing down to $\{1, 3\}$.
2. **FC Stuck:** The agenda eventually becomes empty. Several cells still have $|D| > 1$. The `IsSolved` function evaluates to *False*, meaning the pure deduction phase has halted without a complete assignment.
3. **Backtracking (MRV) and Cascade:** The search controller selects the unassigned cell with the Minimum Remaining Values. Suppose it picks $(0, 1)$ with $D = \{3, 4\}$. It first guesses $v = 3$ by pushing `Assign`$(0, 1, 3)$ into a fresh agenda and invoking `RunFC`. This triggers Rule R3, pushing `Remove`$(0, 2, 3)$ to eliminate 3 from the rest of row 0. The domain $D[0, 2]$ (which was previously $\{1, 3\}$) loses 3, reducing its size to exactly 1 ($D[0, 2] = \{1\}$). Rule R4 immediately fires, pushing `Assign`$(0, 2, 1)$. Concurrently, Rule R5 propagates the new $\max(D[0, 1]) = 3$, enforcing that $(0, 2)$ must be < 3, which perfectly aligns with the new singleton domain. This single heuristic guess creates a powerful chain reaction (cascade) that rapidly collapses the remaining domains, successfully finding the solution without needing further backtracks.

The total number of backtracks on this instance is typically zero or one, because arc consistency eliminates almost all ambiguity after the first FC pass.

3.4. Backward Chaining (SLD Resolution)

3.4.1 Idea

The implemented solver is a hybrid architecture that combines Prolog-style SLD resolution with explicit state-space backtracking.

- **KB construction ($HornConverter$):** Converts a puzzle instance into Horn facts and rules using predicates such as $val(i, j, v)$, $given(i, j, v)$, and $not_val(i, j, v)$.
- **Backward chaining core (fol_bc_or / fol_bc_and):** A Prolog-like SLD interpreter with unification, substitution, DFS goal reduction, cycle detection, and NAF handling.
- **Search controller ($_backtrack$):** Controls assignment of values to cells. At each step, it selects one unassigned cell, queries $val(r, c, v)$ to obtain legal candidates, asserts one candidate as a temporary fact, recurses, and retracts on failure.

Why search is integrated with SLD Resolution: The axiom $\forall i \forall j \exists v\ Val(i, j, v)$ contains existential quantification and cannot be encoded directly as a definite Horn rule. Therefore, the solver uses backtracking for value choice, while the backward chaining engine is used to validate and prune candidates through derivable constraints (mainly not_val).

Technical Implementation Notes:

- **0-based indexing in code:** Internally, rows/columns are represented as $0..N-1$ for direct mapping to Python lists.
- **Cell-level candidate generation with NAF:** The generator rule $val(i, j, v) \leftarrow domain(v),\ naf(not_val(i, j, v))$ is used to propose candidates that are not provably forbidden.
- **Hybrid workflow:** BC serves as a logical inference engine; backtracking constructs a full solution by incrementally asserting/retracting val facts.

3.4.2 Algorithm Analysis

Atoms (Predicates)

The Horn KB used the following vocabulary:

- $val(i, j, v)$: Cell (i, j) is assigned the value v.
- $given(i, j, v)$: Cell (i, j) has the pre-filled clue value v
- $less_h(i, j)$ / $greater_h(i, j)$: Horizontal inequalities between (i, j) and $(i, j+1)$.

- $less_v(i, j)$ / $greater_v(i, j)$: Vertical inequalities between (i, j) and $(i + 1, j)$.
- $less(v1, v2)$: Background arithmetic fact representing $v_1 < v_2$.
- $neq(x, y)$: Background inequality fact representing $x \neq y$.
- $not_val(i, j, v)$: Value v is explicitly forbidden at cell (i, j).

Facts

- **Background facts**: All valid $less(v1, v2)$ and $neq(x, y)$ combinations within the finite domain $1..N$.
- **Instance facts**: $given(...)$ clues, inequality signs, and immediate "boundary pruning" facts ($not_val(...)$) derived directly from extreme inequality conditions (e.g., a cell on the smaller side of an inequality cannot hold the maximum value N).

Rules (Definite Horn)

Constraints are encoded by Horn rules that derive either val (from givens) or not_val (forbidden assignments):

- Given $\Rightarrow Val : val(i, j, v) : -given(i, j, v)$
- Cell uniqueness: If a value is chosen, all others are forbidden in that cell.
- Row/Col uniqueness: If $val(i, j1, v)$ holds, then $not_val(i, j2, v)$ for all $j_2 \neq j_1$.
- Inequalities: Values that violate a $<$ or $>$ constraint trigger a not_val derivation.

Existence / Choice Rule via NAF

To generate candidates for an empty cell, the solver adds:

$$val(i, j, v) \leftarrow domain(v),\ naf(not_val(i, j, v)).$$

A value v is accepted as a candidate for (i, j) when v is in the domain and $not_val(i, j, v)$ cannot be proven.

Unification and Substitution

- $unify(x, y, \theta)$: Computes the Most General Unifier (MGU) for two expressions, returning the substitution dictionary θ or "failure".

- $subst(\theta, expr)$: Applies the substitution θ to goals and rule bodies. Variables are represented as lowercase strings (e.g., 'v', 'i', 'j').

SLD Resolution (AND/OR Search Tree)

- OR node (bc_or): Proves a goal by attempting to match and unify it against the head of any available fact or rule.
- AND node (bc_and): Proves the body of a rule by proving all subgoals sequentially from left to right.
- Evaluation follows depth-first, leftmost goal expansion.

Negation as Failure (NAF) Handling

- $naf(G)$ succeeds iff the engine fails to derive G.
- Inside NAF context ($in_naf = True$), rule expansion for predicate val is disabled. This prevents self-supporting loops between val and $naf(not_val)$.

Optimizations Implemented

- **MRV variable ordering:** Backtracking chooses the unassigned cell with minimum remaining values (MRV) based on current BC query results.
- **Predicate indexing:** Facts and rules are indexed by predicate ($fact_index$, $pred_rule_index$, $exact_rule_index$).
- **Cell-specific index for val:** Additional indexes by cell (i, j) are used for both facts and rules of predicate val, reducing scan cost for queries of the form $val(r, c, v)$.
- **Versioned memoization:** Memo keys include $kb_version$, so cache is reused across queries while remaining correct after assert/retract operations.
- Cycle Detection (visited set): Tracks the active resolution path to prevent infinite recursion in cyclic goal graphs.
- Boundary Pruning: Converting extreme inequalities into immediate not_val facts drastically reduces the search space before resolution even begins.

3.4.3 Pseudocode

Algorithm 5 Master Coordinator

```
function SOLVE(puzzle)
    kb ← HornConverter(puzzle).build()
    add facts domain(1..N)
    add facts val(r, c, v) for all givens
    add generator rules val(i, j, v) : −domain(v), naf(not_val(i, j, v))
    build fact/rule indexes and cell indexes for val
    initialize kb_version ← 1
    for each given (r, c) = v do
        if FOL_BC_ASK(kb, not_val(r, c, v)) succeeds then
            return failure // Contradiction in givens
        end if
    end for
    return _BACKTRACK(kb)
end function
```

Algorithm 6 State Space Manager

```
function BACKTRACK(kb)
    if grid complete then
        return success
    end if
    (r, c, C) ← MRV-SelectCell(kb)
    if C = ∅ then
        return failure
    end if
    for each value in C do
        grid[r][c] ← value
        assert fact val(r, c, value) into kb
        kb_version ← kb_version + 1
        if _BACKTRACK(kb) success then
            return success
        end if
        retract fact val(r, c, value) from kb
        kb_version ← kb_version + 1
        grid[r][c] ← 0
    end for
    return failure
end function
```

Algorithm 7 Inference Interface

```
function FOL_BC_ASK(kb, goal)
    return FOL_BC_OR(kb, goal, theta = ∅, in_naf = false, visited = ∅)
end function
```

Algorithm 8 Goal Resolver - OR Node

```
function FOL_BC_OR(kb, goal, theta, in_naf, visited)
    g ← SUBST(θ, goal)
    if (g, in_naf) ∈ visited then
        return ∅                                        ▷ Cycle detection
    end if
    visited′ ← visited ∪ {(g, in_naf)}
    k ← (kb_version, g, in_naf, θ)
    if k ∈ memo then
        return memo[k]
    end if
    if g is naf(inner) then                             ▷ Negation As Failure
        if FOL_BC_OR(kb, inner, theta, true, visited′) yields no proof then
            return {theta}                              ▷ NAF success
        else
            return ∅                                    ▷ NAF failure
        end if
    end if
    answers ← ∅
    facts ← indexed facts matching pred(g)
    if pred(g) = val and (i, j) of g is grounded then
        facts ← cell-indexed facts for (i, j)
    end if
    for each fact F in facts do
        theta′ ← UNIFY(args(g), args(head(F)), theta)
        if theta′ ≠ failure then
            answers ← answers∪FOL_BC_AND(kb, body(F), theta′, in_naf, visited′)
        end if
    end for
    if not (in_naf and pred(g) = val) then
        choose rule candidates from exact/predicate/cell index
        for each rule R in candidates do
            theta′ ← UNIFY(args(g), args(head(R)), theta)
            if theta′ ≠ failure then
                answers ← answers∪FOL_BC_AND(kb, body(R), theta′, in_naf, visited′)
            end if
        end for
    end if
    memo[k] ← answers
    return answers
end function
```

Algorithm 9 Rule Body Validator - AND Node

```
function FOL_BC_AND(kb, goals, theta, in_naf, visited)
    if goals is empty then
        return {theta}
    end if
    first ← SUBST(theta, goals[0])
    rest ← goals[1 :]
    answers ← ∅
    for each theta′ in FOL_BC_OR(kb, first, theta, in_naf, visited) do
        answers ← answers∪FOL_BC_AND(kb, rest, theta′, in_naf, visited)
    end for
    return answers
end function
```

3.4.4 Illustration

On a query $val(r, c, v)$ for an unassigned cell, the resolver first tries indexed val facts for (r, c), then indexed val rules for (r, c) (plus generic generator rules). The result is a candidate set $\mathcal{C}$.

MRV chooses the cell with smallest $|\mathcal{C}|$. If a candidate $v \in \mathcal{C}$ is tentatively assigned, the solver asserts $val(r, c, v)$ into KB and increments $kb_version$. This makes old memo entries automatically inactive (because memo key includes $kb_version$), while still preserving cache reuse for repeated subgoals inside the same KB state.

If recursion fails, the fact is retracted, $kb_version$ is incremented again, and the next candidate is tried. This loop continues until a complete grid is found or the branch set is exhausted.

3.5. A* Search

3.5.1 Idea

In this project, each search state is a partial Futoshiki assignment, where value 0 denotes an unfilled cell. The A* solver expands states according to

$$f(s) = g(s) + h(s),$$

with the following cost model:

- Each action assigns exactly one value to one empty cell, so each step has unit cost.
- $g(s)$ is the number of assignments already made from the initial state.
- $h(s)$ estimates the minimum number of assignments still needed to reach a complete solution.

The transition model assigns one value to one unfilled cell. To reduce branching, the solver selects the next variable by MRV (Minimum Remaining Values), i.e., the cell with the smallest candidate domain. Before evaluating child states, domains are filtered by row/column uniqueness and inequality constraints; optional AC-3 propagation is then applied to remove unsupported values.

This design combines informed search (A*) with CSP-style filtering (MRV + AC-3), making the exploration significantly more directed than naive uninformed expansion.

3.5.2 Heuristic Function and Admissibility Proof

Let $U(s)$ be the number of unassigned cells in state s. We choose:

$$h(s) = U(s).$$

Equivalently, if N is board size and $A(s)$ is number of assigned cells, then

$$h(s) = N^2 - A(s).$$

Feasibility pruning with AC-3 is used as a separate consistency check: if propagation yields an empty domain, the state is discarded as inconsistent.

Why this heuristic is admissible:

- From a partial state with $U(s)$ empty cells, any complete solution must assign all those $U(s)$ cells.
- Each action can assign at most one cell.
- Therefore the true remaining cost $h^*(s)$ satisfies $h^*(s) \geq U(s) = h(s)$.

Hence $h(s)$ never overestimates the optimal remaining cost, so it is admissible.

Consistency (monotonicity):

- After one valid assignment $s \to s'$, we have $U(s') = U(s) - 1$.

- With unit step cost $c(s, s') = 1$:

$$h(s) = U(s) = 1 + U(s') = c(s, s') + h(s').$$

- So h is consistent as well.

3.5.3 Pseudocode

Algorithm 10 A* for Futoshiki (with MRV and AC-3)

```
Build initial state s_0 from puzzle
Validate givens; if invalid then return failure
Compute domains and heuristic for s_0
Initialize closed as an empty set
Initialize best_g[s_0]
Push s_0 into priority queue by key (f, h, −g)
while priority queue not empty do
    Pop best state s
    if s ∈ closed then
        continue
    end if
    Add s to closed
    if s is goal then return solved grid
    end if
    Select unassigned cell (r, c) by MRV
    for each value v in domain(r, c) do
        if assigning v is consistent then
            Create child state s′
            if s′ ∈ closed then
                continue
            end if
            Compute g(s′)
            if best_g[s′] exists and g(s′) is not better then
                continue
            end if
            Recompute domains (and AC-3 if enabled)
            if no empty domain in s′ then
                Set g(s′) = g(s) + 1, evaluate h(s′), f(s′) = g(s′) + h(s′)
                Update best_g[s′]
                Push s′ into priority queue
            end if
        end if
    end for
end while
return failure
```

3.5.4 Illustration

Consider a 4×4 instance. After loading givens and inequalities, the solver:

1. Initializes domains for all empty cells.
2. Runs consistency filtering; if AC-3 is enabled, unsupported values are removed transitively.
3. Chooses the most constrained empty cell by MRV.
4. Expands candidate assignments in priority order according to $f = g+h$.

Example progression:

- State s_0: 4 cells fixed from clues, several constrained inequalities.
- State s_1: assign value to the MRV cell (domain size 1 or 2), causing further domain reduction.
- State s_2: another forced assignment appears after propagation.
- Goal state: all cells filled, row/column uniqueness and inequalities all satisfied.

This illustrates how propagation shrinks the search tree before deep branching happens.

3.5.5 Algorithm Analysis

Let N be puzzle size (grid N^2 cells), and let b be average branching factor after filtering.

Time complexity (worst case):

- Search may still be exponential in the number of unassigned cells, roughly $O(b^d)$ with depth $d \leq N^2$.
- AC-3 propagation on each evaluated state adds polynomial overhead; practical runtime is dominated by number of expanded states.

Space complexity:

- A* stores open/closed states and domain data, so memory usage is higher than depth-first methods.
- In worst case, space is also exponential in search depth.

Practical behavior:

- The heuristic $h(s) = U(s)$ is admissible and easy to justify, which is suitable for the project requirement on heuristic correctness.
- Because this heuristic is simple, most practical speedup comes from MRV ordering and AC-3 pruning.

- The *closed* set avoids re-expanding visited states, and *best_g* avoids keeping inferior paths to the same state.
- The method is robust for medium-sized puzzles, but memory pressure can increase for larger or weakly constrained instances.

3.6. Brute-force and Backtracking

3.6.1 Idea

Brute-force is a straightforward approach that tries all possible assignments for the empty cells in the Futoshiki puzzle. For a puzzle of size $N \times N$, each empty cell can take a value from 1 to N. The algorithm generates all possible combinations and checks whether they satisfy the constraints (row, column, and inequality constraints). However, this approach is highly inefficient due to the exponential number of possibilities.

Backtracking is an optimized version of brute-force. Instead of generating all possible assignments, it builds the solution step by step and abandons a partial assignment as soon as it violates any constraint. At each step, the algorithm selects an empty cell, tries a valid value, and recursively proceeds to the next cell. If a conflict occurs, it backtracks and tries another value. This significantly reduces the search space compared to brute-force.

3.6.2 Pseudocode

Brute-force:

Algorithm 11 Brute-force

```
function BRUTE_FORCE(grid):
    empty_cells = list of all empty positions
    for each possible assignment of values to empty_cells:
        fill grid with assignment
        if is_valid(grid):
            return grid
    return failure
```

Backtracking:

Algorithm 12 Backtracking

```
function BACKTRACK(grid):
    if no empty cell:
        return grid

    (row, col) = find an empty cell

    for value from 1 to N:
        if is_valid(row, col, value):
            grid[row][col] = value

            result = BACKTRACK(grid)
            if result != failure:
                return result

            grid[row][col] = empty

    return failure
```

3.6.3 Illustration

Consider a 4×4 Futoshiki puzzle with some empty cells.

Brute-force will generate all possible combinations for the empty cells. For example, if there are k empty cells, it will try up to N^k assignments, checking each one against all constraints.

Backtracking, on the other hand, fills the grid step by step. Suppose it assigns a value that violates a constraint (e.g., duplicates in a row or breaks an inequality). Instead of continuing, it immediately backtracks and tries another value. This pruning avoids exploring invalid branches of the search tree, making it much more efficient in practice.

3.6.4 Algorithm Analysis

Brute-force Complexity: The time complexity is $O(N^k)$, where k is the number of empty cells. In the worst case (empty grid), this becomes $O(N^{N^2})$, which is infeasible for large N.

Backtracking Complexity: The worst-case time complexity is still exponential, but significantly reduced in practice due to pruning. The actual

performance depends on how early invalid assignments are detected.

Space Complexity: Backtracking uses recursion, so the space complexity is $O(N^2)$ for the grid plus $O(N^2)$ for the recursion stack in the worst case.

Comparison:

- Brute-force explores all possibilities without pruning.
- Backtracking prunes invalid states early, making it much more efficient.
- Backtracking is the preferred method for solving constraint satisfaction problems like Futoshiki.

3.7. SAT Solver (Using SAT Library)

3.7.1 Idea

The SAT approach transforms the Futoshiki puzzle into a propositional satisfiability problem in CNF (Conjunctive Normal Form). Instead of searching directly over puzzle states, we encode all puzzle rules as logical clauses and let a SAT engine decide whether there exists a satisfying assignment.

In this project, CNF clauses are generated by the `FOLKB` module, then solved by PySAT (Glucose3). If SAT, the returned model is decoded back to an $N \times N$ grid; if UNSAT, the puzzle has no valid solution under given constraints.

3.7.2 Constraint Encoding

For each triple (i, j, v), define boolean variable $X_{i,j,v}$:

$$X_{i,j,v} = \text{true} \iff \text{cell } (i, j) \text{ has value } v.$$

Variable ID mapping used in code:

$$\text{ID}(i, j, v) = i \cdot N^2 + j \cdot N + v,$$

with $i, j \in [0, N-1]$, $v \in [1, N]$, so IDs are in $[1, N^3]$.

Main CNF groups:

- **Cell at least one value:** each cell must take some $v \in \{1, \ldots, N\}$.

- **Cell at most one value:** no cell can take two different values simultaneously.
- **Row uniqueness:** two different columns in same row cannot share the same value.
- **Column uniqueness:** two different rows in same column cannot share the same value.
- **Given clues:** pre-filled cells are encoded as unit clauses.
- **Inequality constraints:** for each adjacent pair with sign $<$ or $>$, all violating value-pairs are forbidden by binary clauses.

This encoding guarantees that any satisfying model corresponds to a valid Futoshiki solution.

3.7.3 Pseudocode

Algorithm 13 SAT-based Futoshiki Solver

```
Build CNF clauses from puzzle constraints using FOLKB
Create SAT solver instance (Glucose3)
Add all CNF clauses to solver
if solver returns UNSAT then
    return failure
end if
Get SAT model (set of literals)
Initialize empty grid N × N
for each positive literal ℓ in model do
    if 1 ≤ ℓ ≤ N^3 then
        Decode ℓ → (i, j, v)
        Set grid(i, j) ← v
    end if
end for
if any cell remains unassigned then
    return failure
else
    return solved grid
end if
```

3.7.4 Illustration

For a 4×4 puzzle:

1. The encoder creates variables $X_{i,j,v}$ for all $4^3 = 64$ combinations.
2. Clauses are generated for Latin constraints (row/column uniqueness), given clues, and inequality symbols.
3. Glucose3 finds a satisfying model, for example including literals that decode to assignments such as $(0, 0) = 2$, $(0, 1) = 4$, etc.
4. After decoding all positive in-range literals, the grid is fully reconstructed and validated as complete.

Compared with incremental state expansion, the SAT method delegates global consistency reasoning to a highly optimized conflict-driven SAT engine.

3.7.5 Algorithm Analysis

Encoding cost:

- Number of variables is N^3.
- Number of clauses is polynomial in N, dominated by pairwise exclusivity and inequality forbidding constraints.

Solving cost:

- SAT is NP-complete in general, so worst-case complexity is exponential.
- In practice, modern CDCL solvers (such as Glucose3) are often very effective on structured constraints like Futoshiki.

Space and implementation trade-offs:

- Requires storing full CNF and SAT internal structures.
- Provides a clean and extensible formulation: adding new logical constraints usually means adding new clause templates.

Practical behavior in this project:

- SAT solver gives deterministic feasibility checking (SAT/UNSAT).
- Performance is strong on many instances, especially when constraints are dense enough to guide conflict learning.

3.8. GUI

3.8.1 Overview

The graphical user interface is implemented with `pygame` and organized into a small set of reusable screens and components. The goal of the GUI is not only to display the puzzle board, but also to provide a smooth workflow for

selecting a puzzle, switching between manual play and AI solving, observing solver progress, and reviewing the final result.

The code is split into three main layers. First, `constants.py` defines the global visual system, including colors, fonts, screen size, and board layout presets. Second, `components.py` provides reusable primitives such as rounded buttons, board cells, and the in-game timer. Third, the `screens` package contains the actual application states: main menu, level selection, deal/input selection, and gameplay.

3.8.2 Screen Flow

The GUI follows a simple state machine driven by transitions returned from each screen handler.

- **Menu screen**: presents three actions, namely Play, AI Solver, and Exit. The AI Solver button opens a dropdown list of supported solvers.
- **Level selection screen**: lets the user choose the puzzle size from the available input sets. The layout adapts to the window width and automatically reorganizes buttons into one or more columns.
- **Deal/input selection screen**: supports a two-step selection flow. The user first chooses the board size, then selects a concrete input file for that size.
- **Game screen**: loads the selected puzzle, renders the board, accepts manual input, and optionally runs an AI solver with step-by-step animation.

This separation keeps navigation logic independent from rendering logic and makes the interface easy to extend.

Figure 1: GUI screen flow from menu to gameplay.

3.8.3 Gameplay Interface

The main gameplay screen is responsible for most of the interaction features. It builds a grid of `Cell` objects from the current puzzle state, marks clue cells as immutable, and highlights the currently selected cell. Invalid entries are detected by the board model and reflected immediately through the cell styling.

User interaction follows standard puzzle controls:

- clicking a cell selects it;
- number keys 1 to N assign values to the selected non-clue cell;
- Backspace, Delete, or 0 clears a cell;
- the timer starts when a puzzle is loaded and stops when the board is solved or the user leaves the game.

The game screen also draws inequality symbols between adjacent cells and updates their color according to whether the relation is currently satisfied. When the board becomes valid and complete, a victory dialog is displayed with the final time and move count.

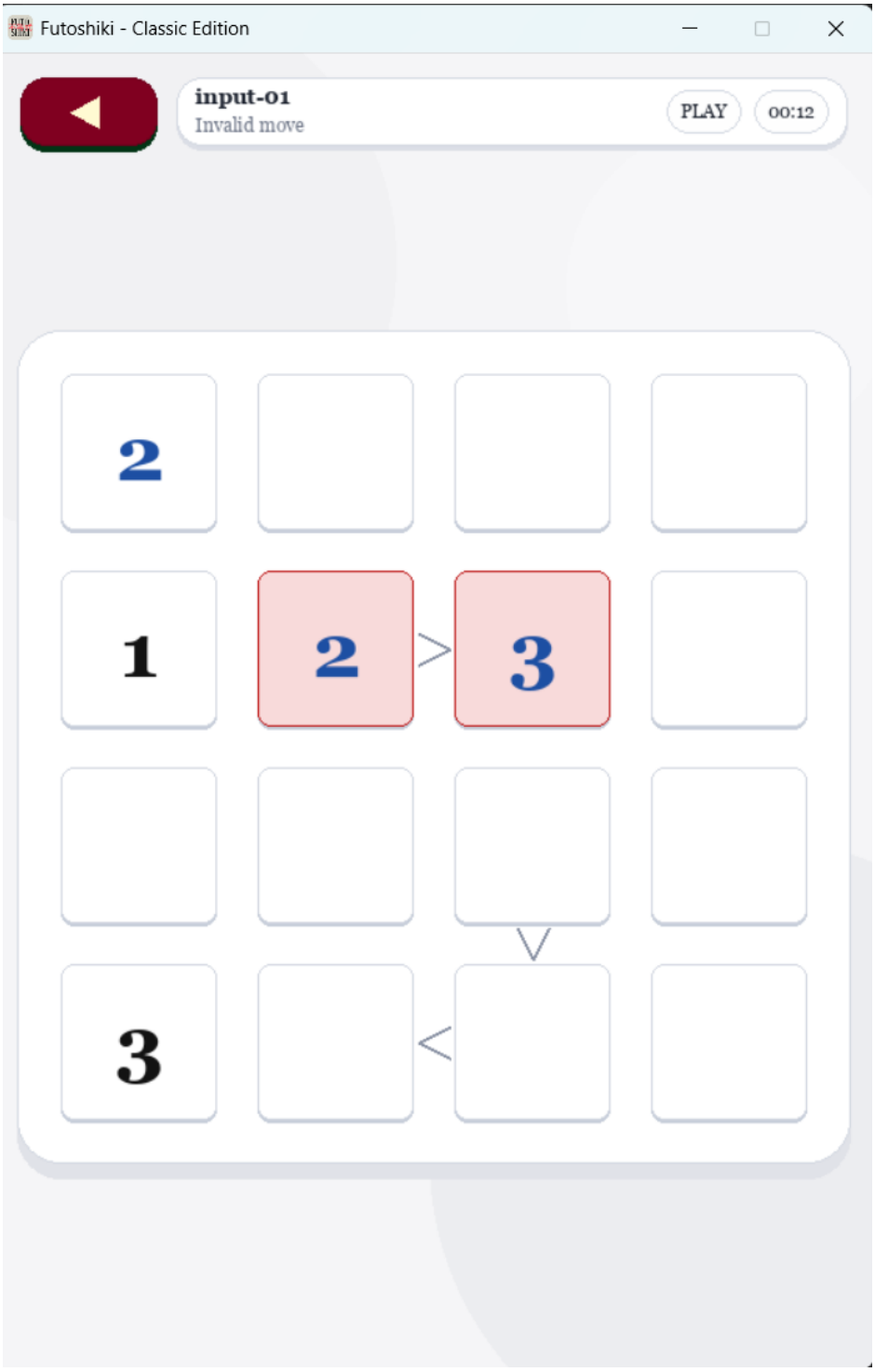

Figure 2: Main gameplay interface in manual mode.

3.8.4 AI Solver Visualization

AI execution is managed by the `AISolverManager` class. Instead of running the solver directly on the render thread, the manager starts a worker thread, streams solver steps through a queue, and applies them incrementally in the GUI. This design prevents the interface from freezing during search and makes the solving process observable.

The manager normalizes solver names, maps them to the available algorithms, and reports status messages such as thinking, backtracking, cancelled, or solver error. Each emitted step is applied to the board one by one, and the impacted cells are redrawn so that animation remains responsive even for larger boards.

Several details improve the AI viewing experience:

- the currently touched cell is highlighted during solver progress;
- backtracking steps are shown with a distinct color to differentiate them from forward assignments;
- the user can skip the remaining animation after the solver finishes;
- when a solution is found, the board is validated again before the victory state is shown.

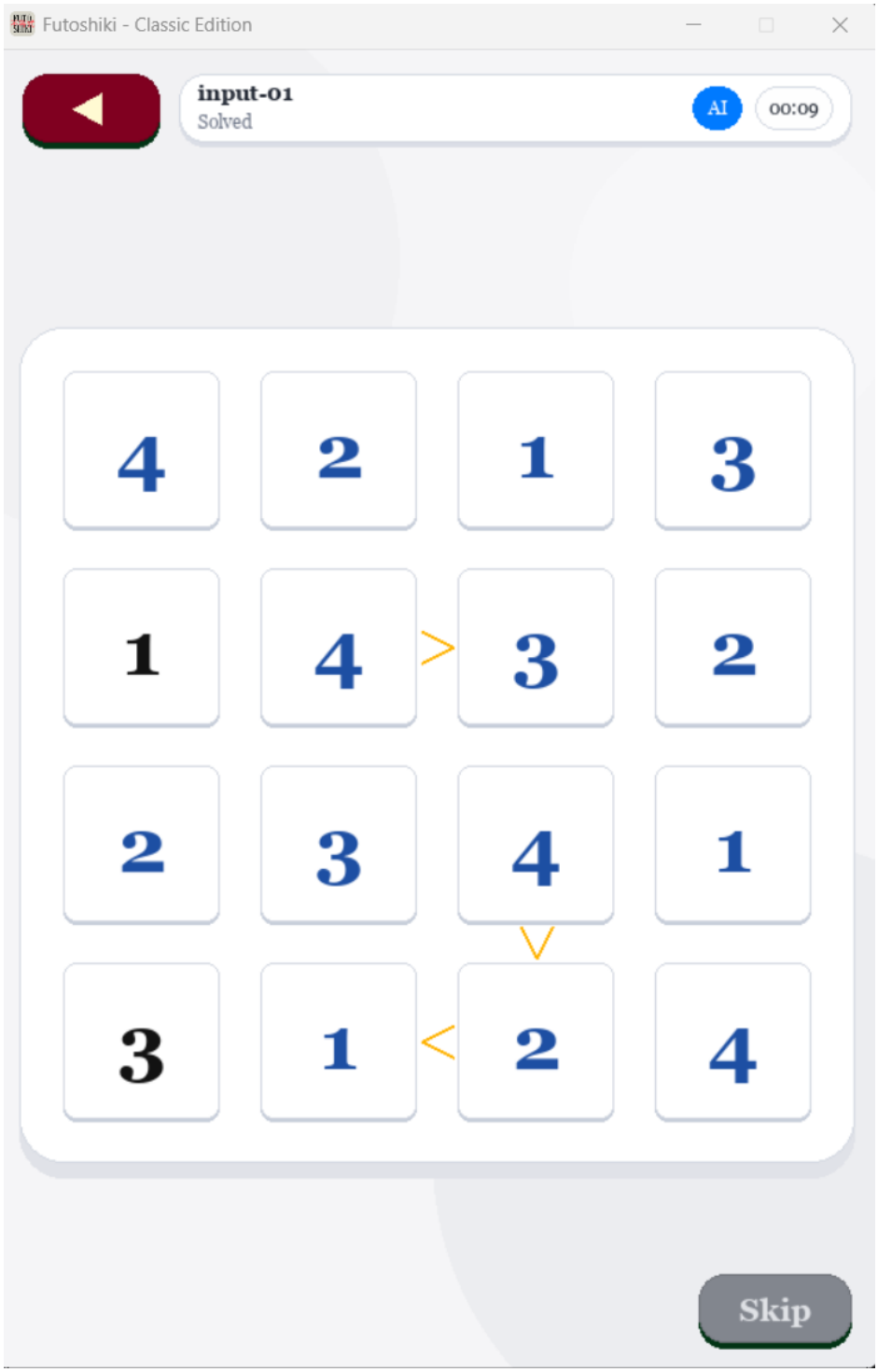

Figure 3: Step-by-step AI solver visualization on the game screen.

3.8.5 Visual Design

The GUI uses a consistent visual system across screens. Colors and layout constants are centralized so that the appearance stays coherent from the menu to the gameplay view. Background rendering is handled by shared helper functions, which either load a background image or fall back to a soft textured pattern.

The reusable `Button` component provides rounded corners, a soft shadow, and hover feedback. This allows the menu, selection screens, and victory dialog to share the same interaction style. As a result, the interface remains compact but still visually clear when moving between the different states of the application.

Overall, the GUI serves as the presentation layer of the project: it connects puzzle loading, manual input, and solver execution into one unified experience while keeping the implementation modular enough for future extensions.

4. Experiments and Evaluation

4.1. Experimental Setup

This section evaluates solver behavior on 10 puzzle instances (`input-01` to `input-10`) with board sizes from 4×4 to 9×9. Experimental results were recorded in `solved.csv` and visualized by `generate_solver_graphs.py`. The primary metrics are runtime (seconds), peak memory usage (MB, measured via `tracemalloc`), and search effort (`node_expanded`).

To keep experiments bounded and reproducible, each solver uses a hard node-expansion cap:

- `MAX_NODES_BRUTE_FORCE = 100000`
- `MAX_NODES_BACKTRACKING = 3000000`
- `MAX_NODES_BACKWARD_CHAINING = 1500000`
- `MAX_NODES_FORWARD_CHAINING = 5000000`
- `MAX_NODES_ASTAR = 5000000`

To prevent unbounded runs, the test harness also enforces a wall-clock timeout of 180 seconds.

4.2. Evaluation Protocol and Metrics

4.2.1 Input and Output Test Cases

The test suite follows project requirements by covering multiple grid sizes and difficulty levels. Each run returns either: (i) a valid solved grid, (ii) `False`/no solution under node cap, (iii) `time_out` at 180 seconds, or (iv) `SKIPPED` for intentionally excluded brute-force cases to avoid intractable runs on larger instances.

4.2.2 Evaluation Metrics

- **Runtime**: elapsed execution time in seconds.
- **Memory Usage**: peak memory footprint in MB.
- **Algorithmic Complexity Proxy**: number of expanded/inferred nodes.

4.3. Experimental Results

4.3.1 Aggregate Statistics (Mean/Median by Solver)

To improve statistical rigor beyond per-instance plots, Table 5 reports aggregate mean and median values per solver. Following the graph-generation pipeline, `SKIPPED` rows are excluded.

Table 5: Aggregate performance statistics by solver (excluding `SKIPPED` rows).

Solver	n	Success Rate	Mean Time (s)	Median Time (s)	Mean Mem. (MB)	Median Mem. (MB)	Mean Nodes	Median Nodes
Forward Chaining	10	100%	0.027218	0.006389	0.090923	0.085709	5004.9	984.5
SAT Solver	10	100%	0.036400	0.009220	0.602800	0.275000	0	0
A* Search	10	100%	1.260518	0.301315	0.182252	0.104591	121.2	38.0
Backtracking	10	90%	6.632425	0.021260	0.002509	0.002480	324446.7	1434.0
BackwardSolver	10	90%	43.366318	2.282411	416.955660	28.340975	735.6	112.5
BruteForceSolver	2	0%	3.037844	3.037844	0.002975	0.002975	100001.0	100001.0

The table clarifies distribution effects that are less visible in individual bars. For example, Backtracking has a low median runtime but a much larger mean runtime, indicating heavy-tail behavior on difficult instances.

4.3.2 Runtime Analysis

Figure 4 reports runtime on a logarithmic scale. Forward Chaining is consistently the fastest method across all inputs, with runtimes typically in the millisecond range and remaining below 0.2 s even on hard instances. A* remains stable and significantly slower than Forward Chaining but generally below 10 s. Backtracking solves most small and medium cases quickly but degrades sharply on difficult boards, reaching approximately 62 s on `input-07`. Backward Chaining exhibits the highest runtime variance and includes one timeout (180 s).

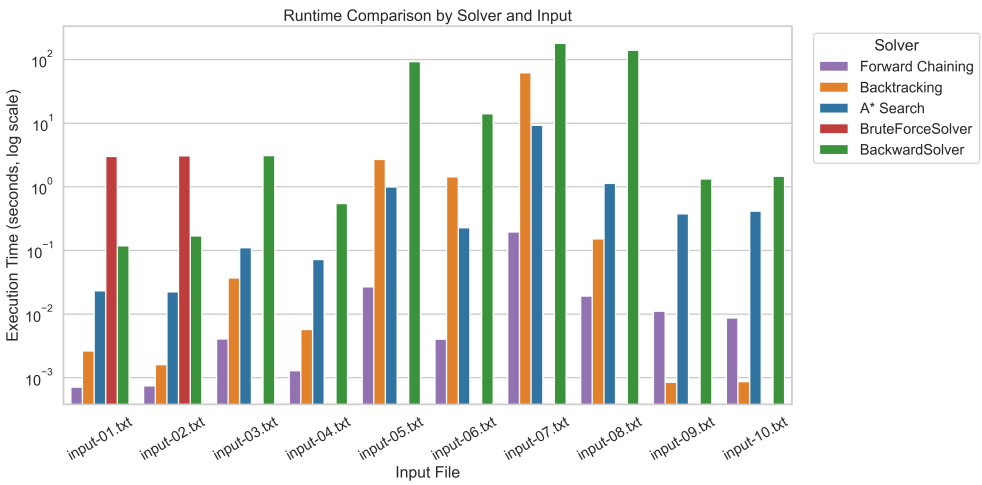

Figure 4: Runtime comparison across inputs (log-scale y-axis).

Why log scale is necessary. Runtime values span several orders of magnitude (from roughly 10^{-3} s to 10^{2} s). A linear y-axis would compress fast algorithms near zero and hide meaningful differences among them. The log scale preserves relative multiplicative gaps, allowing fair visual comparison between very fast and very slow solvers.

4.3.3 Memory Usage Analysis

Figure 5 shows a strong contrast in memory behavior. Forward Chaining, Backtracking, Brute Force, and A* remain memory-efficient (mostly sub-1 MB in this dataset for A* and very low MB for Forward/Backtracking/Brute Force). In contrast, Backward Chaining grows from a few MB on easy

instances to more than 1.8 GB near timeout.

Figure 5: Memory vs runtime trade-off by solver.

Memory explosion in recursive logic search. Backward Chaining combines recursive goal expansion, memoization tables, and dynamically accumulated facts/rules during deep search. On larger, heavily constrained instances, the search tree broadens before contradictions are discovered, causing rapid growth of intermediate states and cached derivations. This is a typical *memory explosion* pattern: memory grows superlinearly with search depth and branching interactions, eventually becoming the primary bottleneck before the node cap is reached.

4.3.4 Algorithmic Complexity (Nodes Expanded)

Node-expansion data confirms the above trends. A* solves with very low node counts (tens to hundreds) due to MRV selection plus AC-3-based pruning and admissible heuristic guidance. Forward Chaining can still be fast despite higher node counts because each propagation step is lightweight and aggressively reduces domains early. Backtracking reaches millions of expanded nodes on difficult cases (close to its cap at 3,000,000). Brute Force quickly hits its cap (100,000) even for small boards. Backward Chaining remains moderate in node count compared with Backtracking but

is expensive per node due to recursive unification and fact/rule management, which explains its high runtime and memory.

4.4. Comparative Analysis

4.4.1 Performance Leader

Based on runtime and completion reliability in `solved.csv`, **Forward Chaining** maintains the leading overall method in this benchmark with a mean runtime of 0.027 s. However, **SAT Solver** achieves a competitive median runtime of 0.0092 s and solves all instances with 100% success, making it exceptionally strong on typical cases. It solved all 10 test cases, achieved excellent speed on most instances, and maintained reasonable memory usage (median 0.275 MB).

In terms of success rate on evaluated cases, Forward Chaining, A*, and SAT Solver all reached 10/10 solved (100%), Backtracking reached 9/10 solved (one failure near node cap), and Backward Chaining reached 9/10 solved with one timeout at 180 s.

The explanation is consistent with Chapter 3: Forward Chaining performs continuous constraint propagation (including inequality propagation and domain pruning similar to local arc-consistency maintenance). SAT Solver benefits from advanced DPLL/CDCL algorithms that efficiently explore the CNF search space. Both methods achieve early elimination of infeasible values, reducing the effective search space.

A* is the second strongest practical solver: it also solved all tested cases with low node expansion because heuristic pruning (MRV + AC-3 feasibility filtering) suppresses unpromising branches.

4.4.2 Preferred Conditions

The recommended use conditions are:

- **Brute Force / Backtracking ($N \leq 5$)**: suitable for small boards or teaching/debugging contexts due to simple implementation and direct interpretability. Backtracking remains practical up to medium difficulty but can degrade abruptly near hard large cases.
- **A* Search**: preferred when a good heuristic is available and controlled search order matters. It is robust for medium-to-large structured

instances because heuristic guidance reduces expansion dramatically.

- **Forward Chaining ($N \geq 6$, low to moderate constraints)**: preferred when rapid constraint propagation is effective. Excels in scenarios with early domain reduction.
- **SAT Solver ($N \geq 5$, any constraint density)**: recommended as a general-purpose solver for diverse puzzle sizes and densities. Outstanding median performance (0.009 s typical) and robust 100% success rate make it a reliable choice. Best for applications where encoding complexity is acceptable.

4.4.3 Trade-off Analysis (Implementation Complexity vs Practical Performance)

Figure 6 summarizes normalized performance (lower runtime, lower memory, lower node expansion produce higher radar scores). Forward Chaining and A* dominate most dimensions; Backtracking is competitive on memory but unstable in runtime on hard cases; Backward Chaining is penalized strongly by memory and runtime growth.

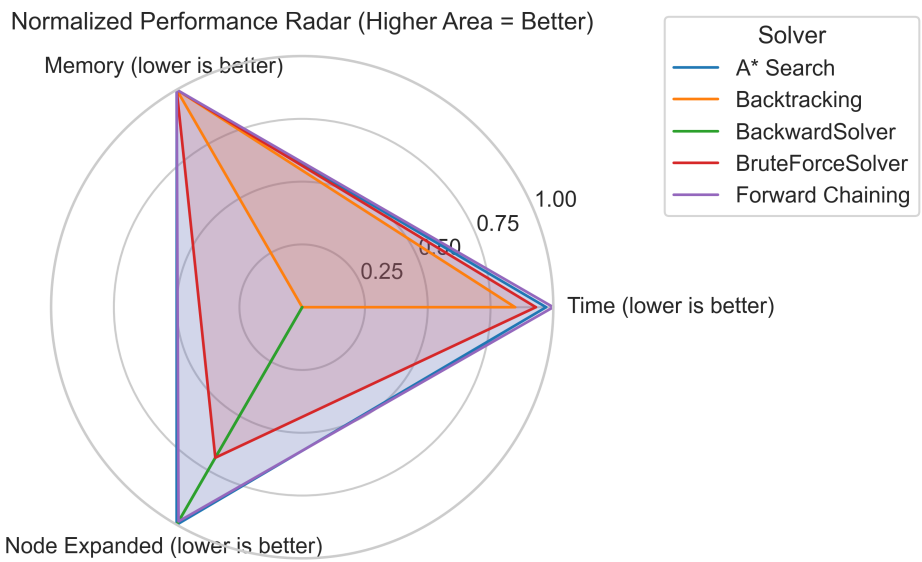

Figure 6: Normalized multi-metric comparison (higher area indicates better overall balance).

From an implementation perspective, the main trade-offs are:

- **Brute Force**: lowest implementation complexity, lowest scalability.
- **Backtracking**: moderate implementation complexity, strong for small-to-medium cases, unstable worst-case behavior.
- **Forward Chaining**: higher implementation effort (rule engine + propagation) but excellent practical balance in this project.
- **A***: high implementation complexity (state modeling, admissible heuristic, consistency checks), very good search efficiency and predictable scaling.
- **SAT Solver**: moderate-to-high implementation complexity (CNF encoding + SAT solver integration) but exceptional runtime performance (median 0.0092 s) and robust 100% success rate, making it an outstanding general-purpose choice despite encoding overhead.

4.5. Self-evaluation Against Project Criteria

The implementation satisfies the key project criteria: multiple solving paradigms were developed (search-based, logic-based, SAT-based), test cases cover the required size diversity, and experiments report runtime, memory, and node-expansion statistics with comprehensive visual analysis. The SAT Solver achieves outstanding empirical results (100% success, median runtime 0.0092 s) and has been fully integrated into the CSV benchmark pipeline. Remaining improvement opportunities include adding per-size aggregate statistics (mean and variance) for stronger statistical rigor and investigating memory usage patterns on larger instances.

5. Conclusion

This project delivers a complete and practical Futoshiki-solving system that combines multiple AI approaches with an interactive GUI. Through implementation and testing, the team verified that different paradigms (search, logic inference, and SAT) can all be applied to the same constraint problem with different trade-offs in runtime, memory, and node expansions.

From an engineering perspective, the project codebase is organized for reproducibility and extension, including standardized input/output handling, solver abstractions, and automated testing. The implementation environment is lightweight and aligned with the project requirements, using

`pygame` for GUI interaction, `python-sat` for SAT solving, and `pytest` for test execution and validation.

Overall, the project objectives were achieved: modeling constraints correctly, implementing representative AI methods, evaluating solver behavior across benchmark inputs, and presenting results through both command-line tests and GUI-based visualization.

6. References

Russell, S. J., & Norvig, P. (2020). Artificial Intelligence: A Modern Approach (4th ed.). Pearson.

A. Appendix

A.1. Generative AI Usage Disclosure

This section documents the use of Large Language Models (LLMs) during the development of this project:

- **AI Tools Used**: Gemini, ChatGPT, Claude.
- **Usage Scenarios**:
  - Code debugging and optimization for search algorithms.
  - Formatting the LaTeX report and troubleshooting matplotlib diagrams.
  - Refining English grammar in the documentation.
- **Sample Prompts**:
  - "How should I enforce row/column uniqueness and inequality constraints efficiently in a Futoshiki backtracking solver?"
  - "In our A* Futoshiki solver, what is a good admissible heuristic to reduce node expansions on 7x7 and 9x9 inputs?"
  - "Help me format a LaTeX table that compares runtime, memory, and expanded nodes across Backtracking, Forward Chaining, Backward Chaining, SAT, and A* for the 10 input files."

A.2. Project Deliverables

- **Demo Video**: A video demonstrating the GUI, manual gameplay, and solver animations can be found at: Click to see video.
- **Futoshiki-Puzzles Project Repository, GitHub**: Click to see repository